

Competitor Scorecard:

Walmart, Costco, Kroger & Sam's Club

with Whole Foods Market on a best-effort basis

Ten-year financial comparison (FY2016–FY2025) built from SEC 10-K filings: capital structure, resilience through 2020–2023, and margin pressure — every ratio a live formula traceable to its XBRL fact.

Prepared by	Ryan Barry
Date	September 18, 2026
Data source	SEC EDGAR — 10-K XBRL filings (companyfacts API and instance documents)
Coverage	Walmart Inc. · Costco Wholesale Corp. · The Kroger Co. — full 10-K coverage FY2016–FY2025 Sam's Club — Walmart reportable segment (ASC 280): sales, operating income, assets; cost of sales FY2022+ Whole Foods Market — standalone 10-Ks FY2016–FY2017; Amazon 'Physical stores' net sales thereafter
Units	USD millions unless stated; fiscal years labelled by SEC frame convention (see Methodology)
Status	All formulas live; recalculated in Excel with zero formula errors

Contents

Executive Summary	Findings against the three key questions, trend shifts, data caveats
Raw Data	As-reported inputs by company and year, named ranges, SEC citations, debt build
Ratio Calculations	Gross margin, operating margin, net margin, current ratio, debt-to-equity, revenue growth
Scorecard	Latest-year ranking per metric with conditional formatting and takeaways
Trend	Native line charts FY2016–FY2025 with the FY2020–FY2023 shock window shaded
Methodology & Tools	Sources, techniques, accounting-policy comparability, assumptions
Data Lineage	Every input value with XBRL tag, accession number, filing date and restatement flag

How to read this workbook

Start here	Executive Summary — the three questions, each answered in one bold line, followed by the evidence. Five minutes.
Then	Scorecard — who is strongest and weakest on each metric this year. Change the year in cell B3 to re-rank any year since FY2016.
Then	Trend — six charts, FY2016–FY2025, with the 2020–2023 shock window shaded. This is where the resilience and margin-pressure answers are visible.
If you want the numbers	Ratio Calculations (every ratio, every year, all formulas) and Raw Data (the as-reported inputs and the debt build).
If you want to verify one	Data Lineage — find the value, click its EDGAR link, open the 10-K. Every input has one.
End here	Methodology & Tools — how it was built, the accounting-policy choices (ASC 606, 842, 280, LIFO) and what they do to comparability.

Personal portfolio project built from public filings only. Not an H-E-B work product; no non-public information used.

Executive Summary

Findings are stated against the three key questions. Every figure quoted below is a live formula into the Ratio Calculations and Raw Data tabs; cited transactions (debt issued, buybacks, charges) are on Raw Data under 'Supporting facts'.

1. Capital structure & financing strategy — who is financed most conservatively, and has that changed?

BOTTOM LINE: Costco. Its leverage is the lowest in the group and has fallen every year since FY2021. Walmart has not changed in a decade. Kroger has tripled its leverage since FY2023 to buy back stock after the Albertsons deal failed – deliberate, but the one red flag here.

- Costco: debt-to-equity 0.45x in FY2016, 0.25x in FY2025. Debt has stayed near \$7.3B; equity has grown from \$12.3B to \$29.2B. It funds growth and buybacks from cash flow, not borrowing.
- Walmart: debt-to-equity has stayed between 0.47x and 0.73x for ten years. Debt is up 12.2% since FY2016 on revenue that is up 46.8%. Leverage is falling relative to the size of the business.
- Kroger: debt-to-equity fell from 2.10x (FY2016) to 1.05x (FY2023), then rose to 2.16x in FY2024 and 2.96x in FY2025. Cause: \$10.5B of debt issued in FY2024 for the Albertsons merger (terminated December 2024), \$4.2B of buybacks that year and \$2.7B more in FY2025. Equity fell from \$11.6B to \$5.9B in two years.
- Why it matters: Kroger is borrowing to return capital, not to grow – revenue has been flat since FY2022. That is a choice, not a mistake, but it leaves Kroger with the least room of the three if margins slip.
- Including operating leases (ASC 842) changes no ranking: FY2025 debt-to-equity is 0.34x Costco, 0.63x Walmart, 4.16x Kroger.

2. Resilience through 2020–2023 — who absorbed COVID and the inflation spike best, and who took the biggest hit?

BOTTOM LINE: Costco absorbed it best – sales, net margin and liquidity all rose through the window. Walmart took the biggest hit, in FY2022, and was back to normal within two years. Kroger's margin swings were fuel mix, not stress.

- Costco: net sales grew 9.3%, 17.7% and 16.0% in FY2020–FY2022. Net margin rose from 2.4% to 2.6%. Current ratio peaked at 1.13x and never fell below 0.97x. Gross margin dipped to 10.5% in FY2022 as Costco held prices through inflation, then recovered to 11.1%.
- Walmart: FY2022 (year ended January 2023) was the low point of the decade – gross margin 23.5%, operating margin 3.4% – as excess inventory was marked down. Current ratio fell from 0.97x to 0.82x. By FY2024 operating margin was 4.4% and FY2025 net margin 3.1% – fully recovered.
- Kroger: gross margin jumped to 23.3% in FY2020 when low-margin fuel sales collapsed, then fell to 21.4% in FY2022 when fuel prices spiked. Net margin held between 1.2% and 2.0%. Its current ratio (0.74x–0.81x) is the lowest of the three by design, not because of the shock.
- Sam's Club: net sales grew 8.7%, 15.1% and 14.7% in FY2020–FY2022 with operating margin between 2.3% and 3.1%. The club format won the pandemic and the trade-down that followed.

3. Margin pressure since 2016 — who has felt it most, and is it cost, pricing, or mix?

BOTTOM LINE: Walmart – and it is pricing and mix, not cost. Gross margin has given up ground while SG&A has held. Kroger's operating margin has fallen further, but that is cost growth and one-off charges below gross profit. Costco shows no pressure. Sam's Club is improving.

- Walmart: gross margin 24.9% in FY2016, 23.5% at the FY2022 low, 24.2% in FY2025; operating margin 4.7% to 4.2%. The gross-margin give-up matches Walmart's price investment and the shift to lower-margin e-commerce and grocery. The gap between gross and operating margin has not widened, so costs are under control.
- Kroger: operating margin 3.0% in FY2016 to 1.3% in FY2025 – the largest decline in the group. FY2025 includes \$2.7B of restructuring and impairment charges; without them operating margin would be about 3.1%. Gross margin is unchanged (22.4% to 23.3%), so the pressure is cost, not pricing.
- Costco: gross margin flat by design (11.3% to 11.1%); net margin up from 2.0% to 3.0%. Membership fees (\$5.3B in FY2025, 2.0% of net sales, no cost of sales) and 132.5% cumulative sales growth do the work.

- Sam's Club: segment gross margin up from 10.4% (FY2022) to 11.3% (FY2025) as mix shifts away from fuel. Whole Foods was already under pricing pressure before Amazon bought it: gross margin 34.4% to 33.7%, operating margin 5.5% to 2.9% in its last two standalone years.

Notable trend shifts since FY2016

- Costco has changed weight class. Net sales grew 17.7% and 16.0% in FY2021–FY2022, taking it from \$116.1B to \$269.9B. It is now 1.8x Kroger's size; it was 1.0x in FY2016.
- Kroger has reversed course. Five years of de-leveraging (FY2018–FY2023) were undone in two: debt-to-equity 1.05x to 2.96x, on revenue growth of -1.9% and 0.4%.
- ASC 842 (FY2019; Costco FY2020) put operating leases on every balance sheet. Total debt here excludes them so FY2016–FY2018 stay comparable; the lease-inclusive ratio above shows the effect.

Data caveats

- Sam's Club is a segment of Walmart (ASC 280), not a filer. Net sales, operating income and total assets are available FY2016–FY2025; cost of revenue only from FY2022 (ASU 2023-07); no net income, current ratio or debt exists at segment level.
- Whole Foods filed its last 10-K for FY2017 (Amazon closed the acquisition 2017-08-28). From FY2018 the only public figure is Amazon's 'Physical stores' net sales, which also includes Amazon Fresh and Amazon Go. Whole Foods' cost line included occupancy costs, so its ~34% gross margin is not comparable to peers.
- Costco revenue is NET SALES, excluding membership fees, to match Walmart's and Sam's Club's basis. Total revenue and the fee line are memo rows on Raw Data.
- Inventory method: Walmart U.S., Sam's Club, Costco U.S. and ~91% of Kroger use LIFO; Costco Canada and Walmart International use FIFO. Kroger's LIFO reserve is \$2.6B at FY2025 (\$1.3B at FY2016), so its reported inventory and cost of sales are below FIFO values. Walmart reported LIFO ≈ FIFO through January 2022 and gives only sensitivity language since; Costco took a LIFO charge worth 19 bp of gross margin in FY2022. Ratios are as reported; the Methodology tab quantifies the effect.
- Total equity includes noncontrolling interests (Walmart: \$6.3B at FY2025); net income is the amount attributable to the parent. Standard presentation; it slightly lowers Walmart's debt-to-equity versus a parent-only basis.
- 53-week years: Costco and Kroger FY2017 and FY2023 each had 53 weeks, which flatters growth in those years and depresses it the year after by roughly 2 points. Fiscal years follow the SEC frame convention, so Walmart's 'fiscal 2026' (ended January 2026) is FY2025 here.
- Every input carries its XBRL tag, accession number and filing date on the Data Lineage tab. Seven values the SEC API could not return were taken from the filing's XBRL instance or derived from two tagged facts; they are shaded yellow on Raw Data.

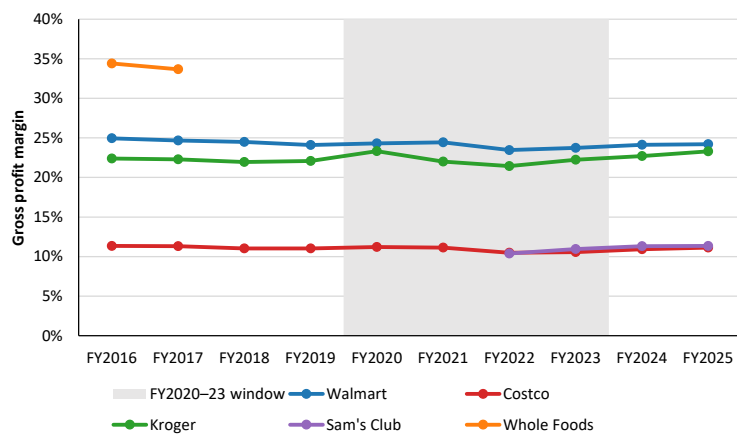
Scorecard year (input)	FY2025	← any year FY2016–FY2025							
Metric	Better is	Walmart	Costco	Kroger	Sam's Club	Whole Foods	Leader	Laggard	Takeaway
Gross profit margin	Higher	24.2%	11.1%	23.3%	11.3%	n/a	Walmart	Costco	FY2025: Walmart leads at 24.2%, Costco trails at 11.1%. Level reflects business model, not execution: warehouse clubs (Costco, Sam's Club) run 10–12% on net sales, supercenters and supermarkets 22–25%. Compare each company's trend on the Trend tab, not levels across models.
rank (of companies with data)		#1 of 4	#4 of 4	#2 of 4	#3 of 4	–			
Operating margin	Higher	4.2%	3.8%	1.3%	2.6%	n/a	Walmart	Kroger	FY2025: Walmart leads at 4.2%, Kroger trails at 1.3%. Operating margin isolates cost discipline below gross profit. Costco's has risen steadily; Kroger's FY2025 figure carries \$2.7B of restructuring and impairment charges.
rank (of companies with data)		#1 of 4	#2 of 4	#4 of 4	#3 of 4	–			
Net profit margin	Higher	3.1%	3.0%	0.7%	n/a	n/a	Walmart	Kroger	FY2025: Walmart leads at 3.1%, Kroger trails at 0.7%. The cleanest cross-model comparison. Costco converts the thinnest gross margin into the highest net margin through membership fees and SG&A control.
rank (of companies with data)		#1 of 3	#2 of 3	#3 of 3	–	–			
Current ratio	Higher	0.79x	1.03x	0.80x	n/a	n/a	Costco	Walmart	FY2025: Costco leads at 1.03x, Walmart trails at 0.79x. Grocers and clubs run near or below 1.0x by design – inventory turns faster than suppliers are paid. A ratio above 1.0x is rare in this set and is Costco's alone.
rank (of companies with data)		#3 of 3	#1 of 3	#2 of 3	–	–			
Debt-to-equity	Lower	0.49x	0.25x	2.96x	n/a	n/a	Costco	Kroger	FY2025: Costco leads at 0.25x, Kroger trails at 2.96x. Kroger's debt-to-equity is a multiple of its peers' after the FY2024 \$10.5B debt issue and \$6.9B of FY2024–25 buybacks; Costco has de-levered every year since FY2021.
rank (of companies with data)		#2 of 3	#1 of 3	#3 of 3	–	–			
Revenue growth YoY	Higher	4.7%	8.1%	0.4%	3.1%	n/a	Costco	Kroger	FY2025: Costco leads at 8.1%, Kroger trails at 0.4%. Costco has led growth in nearly every year of the window; Kroger's revenue has been flat to down since FY2022.
rank (of companies with data)		#2 of 4	#1 of 4	#4 of 4	#3 of 4	–			
Composite rank (average of five core ranks)	Lower	1.8	1.8	2.8	n/a	n/a	Walmart	Kroger	Computed only for the three full filers, which have all five core metrics. Sam's Club and Whole Foods lack the balance-sheet metrics and are not ranked.

Sam's Club: net margin, current ratio and debt-to-equity are n/a (segment reporting). Whole Foods: n/a after FY2017 (acquired). Operating margin is supplementary and excluded from the composite.

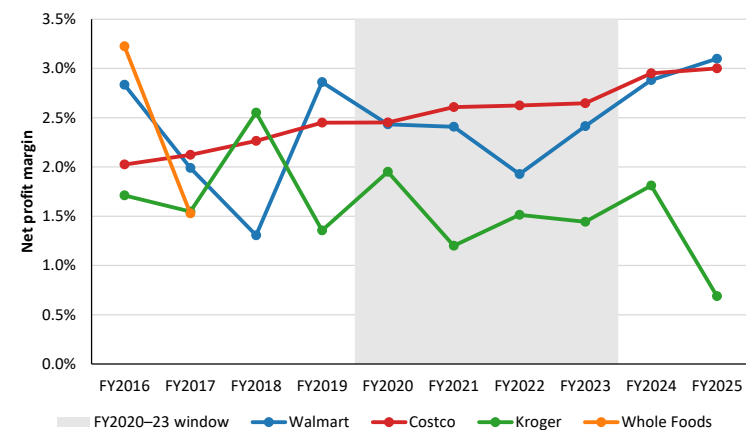
Trend

FY2016–FY2025. Shaded band = FY2020–FY2023 (COVID-19 and the inflation spike). Gaps = data not available (Sam's Club balance sheet, Whole Foods after FY2017); charts read the helper block via NA() so missing years are skipped, never

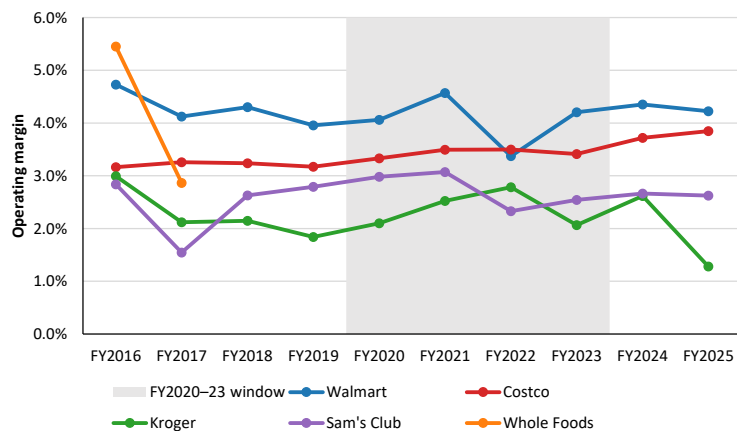
Gross profit margin, FY2016–FY2025



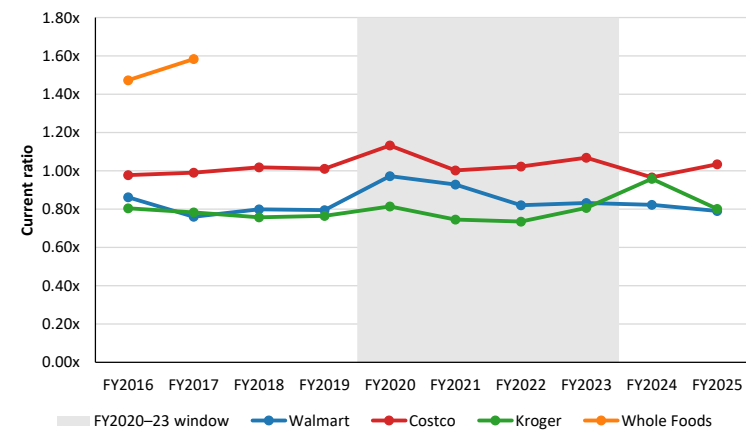
Net profit margin, FY2016–FY2025



Operating margin, FY2016–FY2025



Current ratio, FY2016–FY2025



Debt-to-equity, FY2016–FY2025

Revenue growth YoY, FY2016–FY2025

